Q. You talked about keeping balance in the reforms that were taken up. Yet, in 2016, we saw demonetisation shake up the economy. What are the lessons from its implementation?

The fact remained that for a major step on that scale for removing black money because of high denomination notes, people accepted it. They said Prime Minister Modi's intentions are very clear; yes, there are difficulties, we'll face them. A corollary to it is the way people went into digital mode of payment post that, even more because of Covid. And you're saying that India has set a leadership role for itself, not just the leaders, (but also) common people, the way in which they've adapted to it. Some of the leaders who come from abroad are fascinated by the way the *nariyalpaniwala* uses it, the *thelawala* uses it, even in the remotest villages.

Q. And yet some people say cash is back in full amount and, therefore, the whole purpose of demonetisation stands defeated, it is a failure.

What did they expect? Did they have a blueprint of what demonetisation was before the prime minister brought it in? Can the PM, particularly when you're bringing in demonetisation of all high-value currency, sit with all parties and say, "Look, you tell me the muhurat, I'll introduce it and then we'll do it?" What was their argument at that time? You're attacking the stock of black money, you're not talking about its flow. Here is a prime minister who comes in in 2014 and the first file he signs is to set up a special investigation team to look into matters of black money. Post that, one after the other, legislative measures are taken to make sure action is taken against people who are stacking money abroad. Post that, you bring in certain KYC (Know Your Customer) practices into banks, run banks professionally, see where the money is going, whose money is coming. Politically sensitive individuals, or (those who fall afoul of) the FATF (Financial Action Task Force) Act, are expected to be red-flagged as and when a major quantum of cash is transferred from one account. These are all steps Prime Minister Modi has taken.

Q. And has the quantum of black money reduced?

At least you are able to track it all down and take action. And look at the way the Enforcement Directorate or the Central Bureau of Investigation is going after stacks and stacks of money kept in homes or in toilets or in farmhouses. Are these not efforts towards eliminating black money? When we do it, they say, "Oh my God, you unleash these agencies." And when we don't, they ask, "What have you done about it?"

"You need more data to talk meaningfully about jobs. India doesn't have that data. We tend to draw conclusions for the entire economy from data on formal jobs"

"The informal sector today has shown much buoyancy. Do start-ups not create jobs? New sectors—solar, green energy—are coming up. Are they run by one individual?"

Q. A major issue that has come up this election is the lack of jobs. Opinion polls, including those by INDIA TODAY, are showing that unemployment is the No. 1 issue in the country today. What do you have to say?

There's no denying the fact that you need more data to talk meaningfully about jobs. India doesn't have it, and I'm not saying that with a sense of complacency. I fully recognise that there is a need for good, reliable data, both for jobs in the formal sector and, equally or more importantly, about informal sector jobs. Once we get some data for the formal sector, we seem to reach a conclusion for the entire economy, which is not right. The informal sector today has shown much buoyancy. Let's answer these questions. Do startups function in isolation? The last figure, I think, was 97,000 start-ups, which got registered in the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT). That is, after 2016, when (the Start-up India scheme) was launched. You think they don't create jobs? Are they one single person running a company? Second, the new sectors coming up—renewable energy, green ammonia, solar particularly—how many are we seeing in terms of large solar firms? Do you think they run with one individual? Then, through the PM SVANidhi, and the PM Mudra, the number of people who have taken loans which are collateral-free. I want to ask the Congress which talks of Nyay, when loans are going to small people, you ignore them completely and instead condemn them saying Modi is giving loans only to his friends. So, are these Ambanis and Adanis? Also, under the government Rozgar Mela, in the past 12 months, commencing November 2022 to October 2023, 10 lakh jobs that were vacant have been filled.

Q. The criticism is regarding self-employment, which is largely disguised employment or underemployment, in comparison to formal jobs.

This underemployment logic cannot work when people are taking money from the bank and doing their own business.